Chapter 2: *The person as author of behavior*

There is a great difference between animals and human beings; even though both are living creatures, only man is a person. The animal comes into existence with a given nature which determines its way of acting; animals act on instinct or through having been forced to learn something. However, the human being has been created with a free nature which is capable of knowing and loving; this means that man has to learn how to do nearly everything, he doesn't know by instinct what to do or how to act. He has to learn to walk, to eat, to drink, to speak, to read; he has to learn how to live as the person he is.

Definition and concept of the person

"Person" is a philosophical concept that has a long history; we will now take a look at how the concept developed. The Greek term *prosopon*: literally the term means "that which is put in front of the eyes"; it was used to refer to the masks that actors used to wear in the Greek theatre. The actors represented the different characters by using a mask (postpone) which identified them for the audience as acting a particular role.

The Latin term *personae* means "to resound or to speak through". This term began to be applied to the masks used by actors as their voices resounded through the masks. This meaning became common and was used generally. So "person" meant the mask that the actor used; then the term began to be extended to mean the role played by the actor and finally, the term came to be used to indicate the actor himself, the man.

In this context, the word "person" was used in the form "per se sonans"; that is, he who speaks for himself or who has his own voice. This meaning was enlarged so as to refer the person who has rights, dignity and social recognition; this became the meaning of the term in Roman Law. In Rome, "persons" were those people who has rights, free men with a vote because they were members of important families. To be a person meant to have rights and social dignity.

But not everyone in Rome were persons in this sense; slaves were considered to be animals or things; foreigners were not persons, neither were those men who did not come from important families considered to be persons; women also had less social significance and fewer rights. In short, in the Greek and Roman traditions, the person was a man, with a certain dignity.

Due to the need that Christians had to try to explain their faith in God as three different persons in one divine nature, philosophical and theological thought during the first 5 centuries of Christianity developed and focused on concepts such as person, substance and nature. *Person* was understood as that which is singular, proper and subsists by itself (person as substance). *Nature*: a way of being or existing that which is common to various beings.

These intellectual developments were summed up in the concept of person established by Boethius, a Roman thinker from the 5th-6th centuries (+ 525): the person is *"an individual substance of a rational nature"*[2].

"An individual substance" is something which exists in and by itself (not relying on anything else to exist such as the white or the green needs the writing board in which

[2] *De duabus naturis*, ch. 3, PL 64, 1343.

they can exist as accidents); it is a whole and undivided thing in itself, and it exists separately from other things; a car, a computer. In a certain sense, it is absolute in as much as it doesn't need other things in order to exist. As an individual, it is an existential unity which is different from other things of the same species. For example: a table = a whole thing which doesn't depend on anything else; it is different from the other tables, even though they have exactly the same shape, colour, etc.

However, not all individual substances are persons; the table is not a person. What makes the individual substance be a person? According to Boethius, it is the fact that the substance is of a rational nature; that is, it has the capacity for self-conscious, reflective and abstract thought. As the person has a rational nature, he has a particular essence or way of being which makes him capable of reasoning, of inferring, so that, from understanding some known thing, he can come to grasp or know some unknown thing.

Rationality distinguishes the way of being of the person from that of other individual substances. Rationality makes the way of being of the person different from the way of being of another individual substance, such as a chair. So, being a person means being a subject (individual substance) of a rational nature whose most significant property is that of being he himself the internal source of his own free decisions.

In reaction to the two world wars of the 20th century, the stream of philosophical thought known as personalism developed; it was based on the discovery of the importance of each individual person and the need to study the person combining modern concepts such as awareness, subject, self, freedom, dynamicity, etc., with the ideas coming from a realist philosophy that is open to the transcendent dimension in the person.

This has given rise to an understanding of the human person that may be described as follows: the person is a being who has his own dignity; he needs to give himself to others in order to achieve his own perfection; he is dynamic and active, and capable of transforming the world; he is capable of knowing the truth; he is spiritual and corporeal; he has a freedom that permits him to determine himself and to decide at least partially, his future and his way of being; he is rooted in the world of feelings and affectivity and he carries in himself and is destined to reach a transcendent goal.

Phenomenological features of the person

Substantiality-subsistence: the person is a being who has such a strong existential density that he remains the same, in spite of changes; the person is always the same even though the world around him changes and even though he himself changes. This is so because the person exists in and by himself, independently of other creatures, due to his act of being; that which makes him be and be real. Even though the human being changes internally and externally, even organically, he continues to be the same person. This fact of being he himself is deep and decisive, because it means that the person consistent being who can resist the passing of the days and years; he is even eternal in a certain sense. This is what we refer to when we speak of the subsistence of the personal being.

Intimacy-subjectivity: That which remains the same when there are changes in the person is not a "thing", but rather, a "who"; someone; a very deep reality with great inner

richness which manifests itself and expresses itself through special qualities: sensitivity, feelings, emotions, self-awareness, etc. All these characteristics constitute the person's subjectivity; that is, that which is proper and specific to each person, his intimate, inner world, which is different to that of any other person. This "world" can be manifested, partially, through feelings and actions; but it is also partly inexpressible because it constitutes the very identity of the person, which cannot be transferred or communicated. Also, the person understands himself as an autonomous being, aware of himself and independent; that is, he understands that he is someone, a subject, an "I" who is capable of making decisions about himself and of presenting himself to the world. Karol Wojtyla said that the person is someone who "possesses himself" (Wojtyla, K., *Persona e atto*, p. 132).

A corporeal, special and temporal being: the person has a material and corporeal dimension also; he is subjectivity and intimacy in a specific, physical and particular body; he is a "corporeal someone" (Marias, J., *Persona*, Alianza, Madrid 1997, p. 135). This brings with it many consequences, one of which is the fact that he is not a purely spiritual being, but rather he can be located in space and time. Space: the person moves within physical, geographical and human space which he needs in order to live and which conditions him: house, city, country, etc. Time: the person is not a static being, but rather, he is in constant evolution; he has a life span which unfolds and which makes him dynamic and capable of having projects. The person lives in time, with which he is constantly struggling. On the one hand, he tries to detain time by keeping memories from the past and eternalizing the present when it pleasant and makes him happy. At the same time, he tries to anticipate (bring forward) the future in order to decide on his destiny and to exercise that control over himself that characterizes him. However, death always comes and time runs out although the longing for eternity which lies within every man, also requires an explanation

Openness and definition: although the person has his own personal and untransferable life, he is not a being that is closed in on itself, rather he is open; he needs to transcend (go beyond) himself in order to develop fully. All men need to go out of themselves and to make themselves a gift to others if they want to achieve personal fulfillment; he does this through his higher, spiritual faculties. Man relates to the real world at three different levels: with things; interpersonal relations with other people and with God. This relation always works in two directions: reception and influence; man is affected by the world around him, but at the same time, through his action he can change this world and transform it according to his desires and needs. This openness does not involve the modification of an undifferentiated being, but rather, it involves the perfecting of a well defined being with a specific nature. "(The person is) at the same time open and closed. He is closed due to the immanence of his past in his present through the condensing of his whole history in the present moment thanks to a general evaluation that, balancing out his conquests and his achievements, establishes the validity of that which the person has managed to do with himself. He is open because his present moment opens up to the future, he is filled with an impulse that places him before himself, because the requirements that move him oblige him to take new decisions and to dedicate himself ever more to the task in which the person recognizes himself" (Pareyson, L., *Esistenza e persona*, p. 181).

Man and woman. When we speak about the person we do so in an abstract way because, in reality, there exists two different types of human person (but not one human person as such): man and woman. There are no abstract human persons, but rather male human persons or female human persons each of whom offer a wonderful diversity which is full of mystery and complementarity. We do not mean by this that man and woman are two different types of being; they are both essentially equal to each other, but the specific way in which their personal being is constituted, while being equal in the deepest dimensions, are different in their specific manifestations. Corporality, sensitivity, psychology, intelligence and affectivity follow different paths in man and in woman, and in this way they unendingly enrich the world of the personal being. These are the main phenomenological characteristics of the human person that distinguish him from any other type of being.

Dignity of the person

Men and women are very special beings whose intrinsic perfection places them over and above all other natural beings. St Thomas Aquinas said that *persona significat id quod es perfectissimun in tota natura* (person means that which is the most perfect (being) in the order of nature (natural order) (Thomas Aquinas, S. Th. I, q. 29, a. 3, a. 4). In our day and age, this perfection has a specific name: dignity.

The person is the most excellent dignified (perfect, worthy) being in comparison with the cosmos, material things, plants and animals. In spite of the intrinsic perfection of the universe and the various natural organisms as shown to us in an ever more fascinating way by science, the human being is radically above them because he exists on a higher level, that of the spirit and personal being. As a result, we can say that the person is dignified in the most radical sense.

The dignity of the person is an intrinsic and constitutive perfection; that is, it depends on his very existence and on the essential characteristics of his being; it does not depend on the possession of any capacity to exercise certain qualities. Every person has this dignity by the very fact of being a person although he may lack or have in a defective way some of the specific elements of the human being (physical or psychic incapacities, lack of development of certain aspects, etc).

In other words, one is either a person or not a person in a radical way, but one cannot be more or less of a person. Abortion and euthanasia are wrong precisely because they limit the conditions for being a person, with the corresponding dignity, to the possession of certain physical or psychic qualities (self-awareness, satisfactory quality of life, etc.). The dignity of the person means that he is a value in himself, by the very fact of being a person and of existing and so, cannot (ought not) be instrumentalised.

Due to this fact, we have the positive obligation to seek the person's good and the negative obligation not to make use of the person like an instrument for obtaining other goals, as this would go against his dignity. Such instrumentalisation of the person would meaning identifying the person with a thing and leaving aside his personal nature.

The value of the person is absolute; this means that he is of greater value than any other creature or value that we may come across, be it in nature, animals, material things or spiritual goods. It also means that this value (the person) cannot be changed, manipulated or substituted by anything else; there should be no attack on the dignity of

the person. Rather, our attitude to the person should always be that of respect, recognition, and promotion

The dignity of the person is the basis for human rights: the absolute value and intrinsic dignity of the person is manifested at the juridical and social level in human rights or the fundamental rights that the person possesses by the very fact of being a person. We have subjective rights. For example, social freedom at different levels ought to be respected: religious freedom, freedom of expression, right to personal intimacy, etc. These are rights based on the inner needs of the personal being and are only recognised by the State, but not actually conceded by the State. We also have objective rights: the State ought to facilitate the necessary conditions so that the person can exercise his rights effectively and without being hampered (right to education, a living, etc.).

The dignity of the person means that each man and woman are unrepeatable and cannot be substituted: the specific characteristics of the human being permit us to understand that the person is unique and has unrepeatable value independently of his physical, intellectual or other conditions. In the strict sense, no one can be substituted by another person; this is especially clear in the context of the family and other relations where love is involved.

The defense of each person's dignity is historically linked to Christianity. The very notion of person developed in the context of Christianity. It is also true that the awareness of the intrinsic dignity of each person, independently of sex, culture, wealth, and so on has developed thanks to Christianity. However, with time, this awareness has become more generalised and has been accepted as a civil value by other societies and cultures. In Ancient times, this was not the normal practice: slavery, limitation of civil rights according to education, sex, race, etc., were common and have been overcome little by little. Nowadays, in principle there is general recognition of the dignity of every person who is born normal; however, this recognition tends to be reduced or restricted in the cases in which the person is weaker such as Before birth (abortion) or at the time of death: euthanasia.

As we shall see with more detail, ultimately, the dignity of the person resides in the very fact that he is a person, that is, the fact that he is constituted by body and spiritual soul, with intellect, will, and so many other human faculties.